desecration: the contractors went home, but the transportation ministry had to call in more than 100 employees to organize shuttle buses and other emergency transit.

The trains, for their part, finally got rolling again on Sunday evening, after a 24-hour delay. The first northbound service made it halfway to Haifa, then screeched to a halt after it hit a wild boar.

Outsmarting God

One of Israel's most unique traditions is the *shmita*, a fallowing of the fields that occurs every seven years. The Torah forbids farmers from plowing or planting; fruits or vegetables that grow naturally are considered public property, and may not be sold. The sabbatical is mandated repeatedly in the Torah, but only within the borders of the ancient lands of Israel. For farmers in the diaspora, from Brod to Baghdad, it was an irrelevant injunction.

It finally became relevant again in the late nineteenth century, as the first large waves of Jewish immigrants settled in Ottoman Palestine. A year-long break would have been devastating for newly-arrived farmers struggling to work the land and feed themselves. But the early Zionist rabbis were keen to honor the Biblical commandment. Their solution was called a *heter mechira*, literally a "permit of sale". Shortly before the start of the seventh year, Jewish farmers would sell their land to non-Jews, albeit temporarily: ownership would automatically revert back one year later. Nonetheless, the sale would remove the obligation to observe the *shmita*, which is only incumbent upon Jewish-owned land. Israel uses a similar sleight of hand before Passover, when the chief rabbis ceremoniously "sell" the country's *chametz* to an Arab citizen, a jovial hotelier from Abu Ghosh, before the holiday. (The contract is voided eight days later, when the buyer inevitably fails to pay the $150 million bill for the national stockpile of bread.)

There is a well-worn joke that goes roughly like this: some years ago, a young Jewish man bought a non-refundable plane ticket to attend his sister's wedding in New York. The ticket, unfortunately, required him to travel on Shabbat. Eager to attend the wedding, however, and unable to afford a different flight, he asked his rabbi if such a thing would ever be permissible. After a moment of thought, the rabbi offered a solution. "Keep your seatbelt fastened," he said. "Then you are not riding the plane, you are wearing it."